

DynamicBA — Installation Guide

Two small programs, running on your own computer — no account, no cloud,
nothing sent anywhere else

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1. What You Are Installing

DynamicBA is made of two small programs that run together on your own computer:

- The Server — keeps all the data (clients, engagements, users) and enforces who is allowed to see or change what.
- The Web App — the screens you see and click in your browser.

Nothing is sent to any outside company by default. There is no account to create anywhere except inside DynamicBA itself. Everything runs on your own machine at addresses that only your computer can see (localhost). The one optional exception is described in Section 7: if you choose to turn on AI-generated draft specs, DynamicBA sends that project's Statement of Work to Anthropic's API to draft the specs — nothing else, and only if you set that up yourself.

You do not need to be a programmer to follow this guide. You will type a small number of exact commands into a window called a Terminal (on Mac) or Command Prompt / PowerShell (on Windows). Every command is given to you exactly as it should be typed.

2. What You Need Before You Start

- A Windows, Mac, or Linux computer.
- Node.js installed — this is the one piece of free software DynamicBA needs. If you are not sure whether you have it, Section 3 shows you how to check.
- The DynamicBA application folder (the one this guide came with), unzipped somewhere easy to find, such as your Desktop.

3. Step 1 — Install Node.js (Skip if Already Installed)

- Open a Terminal (Mac: press Cmd+Space, type Terminal, press Enter. Windows: press the Start button, type PowerShell, press Enter).
- Type `node -v` and press Enter.
- If you see a version number like v20.11.0 or higher, Node.js is already installed — skip to Step 2.
- If you see an error such as "command not found," you need to install it.
- To install it: go to the official Node.js website (nodejs.org) in your browser, download the version marked "LTS" (Long-Term Support) for your operating system, and run the installer, clicking "Next" through the default options.
- Close and reopen your Terminal, then type `node -v` again to confirm it now shows a version number.

4. Step 2 — Start the Server

The Server is the part that stores your data. You will leave this window open and running the whole time you use DynamicBA — think of it like turning on the lights before entering a room.

- Open a Terminal window.
- Navigate into the server folder inside the application folder you unzipped. For example, if you unzipped DynamicBA to your Desktop, type: `cd Desktop/dynamicba/server`
- Install the Server's components (only needed the first time): `npm install` — this takes a minute or two. You will see a lot of text scroll by — that is normal.
- Make a copy of the settings file (only needed the first time). Mac/Linux: `cp .env.example .env` — Windows: copy `.env.example .env`
- (Optional, but recommended) Load DynamicBA with five example clients and ten example engagements so there is something to explore right away: `npm run seed` — this also creates a ready-to-use login: email `admin@dynamicba.demo`, password `DemoAdmin123!`
- Start the Server: `npm run dev`
- You should see a line saying "DynamicBA API server listening on `http://localhost:4000`" — leave this window open.

5. Step 3 — Start the Web App

Now open a second, separate Terminal window (leave the first one running) for the part you actually see and click.

- Open a new Terminal window.
- Navigate into the web folder in the same application folder. For example: `cd Desktop/dynamicba/web`
- Install the Web App's components (only needed the first time): `npm install`
- Start the Web App: `npm run dev`
- You should see a line with a web address, typically `http://localhost:5173` — leave this window open too.

6. Step 4 — Open DynamicBA in Your Browser

- Open your web browser (Chrome, Edge, or Firefox).
- Go to the address shown in the second Terminal window — usually `http://localhost:5173`
- If you ran `npm run seed` in Step 2, sign in with email `admin@dynamicba.demo` and password `DemoAdmin123!`
- Otherwise, click "Create one" and follow the on-screen steps to set up your own account and consulting firm.

You now have DynamicBA fully running on your own computer. The companion DynamicBA User Guide walks through every screen.

7. Optional — Enable AI-Generated Draft Specs

Step 2 of the engagement wizard has a "Generate Draft with AI" button that drafts automation candidates, use cases, business rules, controls, KPIs, and risks from that project's own Statement of Work, using the Anthropic (Claude) API. It is entirely optional — everything can still be typed in by hand — and takes one minute to turn on:

- Get a free API key at console.anthropic.com.
- `Sign in to DynamicBA and go to Admin!` `AI Provider`.
- Paste the key, choose a model (Claude Sonnet 5 is the recommended default), and click Save.
- Every project in your Organization can now use "Generate Draft with AI" — no restart needed.

The key is stored only in your own server's local data file (`server/data/db.json`) and is sent only to Anthropic's API to generate drafts — never anywhere else. A technical alternative: set `ANTHROPIC_API_KEY` in `server/.env` instead, which every Organization on that server will then share automatically without anyone pasting a key into the app.

8. Using DynamicBA Again Later

You do not need to repeat the install steps every time. Each time you want to use DynamicBA:

- Open a Terminal, go to the server folder, and run: `npm run dev`
- Open a second Terminal, go to the web folder, and run: `npm run dev`
- Open `http://localhost:5173` in your browser.

To stop DynamicBA, click into each Terminal window and press `Ctrl+C` (`Cmd+C` is not used for this — `Ctrl+C` works on Mac too, in the Terminal).

Your data (clients, engagements, everything) is saved automatically in a file inside the server folder, so it is still there the next time you start it up.

9. Troubleshooting

"command not found: npm" or "command not found: node"

Node.js is not installed, or your Terminal needs to be reopened after installing it. Repeat Section 3.

The browser page says "Can't reach the DynamicBA server"

The Server (Step 2) is not running, or its Terminal window was closed. Reopen a Terminal, go to the server folder, and run `npm run dev` again.

"Port 4000 is already in use" or "Port 5173 is already in use"

Something else on your computer, or a previous copy of DynamicBA, is already using that address. Close any other Terminal windows running DynamicBA, or restart your computer, then try again.

I want to start over with no data

Stop the Server (`Ctrl+C` in its Terminal window), delete the file `server/data/db.json`, and start the Server again. It will recreate an empty database.

I forgot my password

This local version does not send password-reset emails. Ask whoever set up your Organization to check `server/data/db.json`, or simply create a new account.

"Generate Draft with AI" says no AI provider is configured

An Organization Admin has not set one up yet (Section 7) — this is optional, and every field can still be filled in by hand in the meantime.

10. Appendix — For a Technical Deployer (Optional Reading)

Everything above is enough to run DynamicBA for yourself or a small team on one computer. If you later want to make it available over the internet to a whole company, or to real paying customers, an IT professional should additionally consider the points below before going live.

Topic	What to Change
JWT_SECRET	Set server/.env's JWT_SECRET to a long, random, private value before exposing the Server to the internet — the example value is not secure.
Database	The built-in file database (server/data/db.json) is simple and dependency-free, good for one machine. For multiple simultaneous users at scale, swap it for a real database (e.g. PostgreSQL) behind the same functions in server/src/db.js — no other file needs to change.
HTTPS	Put the Server behind a reverse proxy (e.g. Caddy or Nginx) that terminates HTTPS before it is reachable from the internet.
Process manager	Run the Server with a process manager (e.g. pm2 or a systemd service) so it restarts automatically if the machine reboots.
Licensing	Plan changes are currently made directly by an Organization Admin (Admin! Licensing). Before payment provider (e.g. Stripe) via a webhook that updates the licence record instead.
CORS_ORIGIN	Set server/.env's CORS_ORIGIN to the exact public web address the Web App will be served from.
AI Provider key	The Anthropic API key (Section 7) is stored in plain text in server/data/db.json or server/.env. For a shared/production deployment, keep server/.env out of version control and restrict file permissions on server/data/db.json.

None of this is required to use DynamicBA yourself or with a small team on one computer — it only matters when opening the application up to the wider internet.

11. End of Installation Guide

For day-to-day usage of DynamicBA once installed, see the companion DynamicBA User Guide, which includes a full walkthrough of the four-step engagement wizard and a library of usage scenarios with suggested sample data.